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Volume XXXIII Number 33; For the week August 12-18, 2008, released on August 11
● Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001. Phones: 23315801-4;
Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi

● Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301;
Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and
Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080;
e-mail: we care@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 24444358 ● Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to
General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,
New Delhi ● Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 ● Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor,
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prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press
India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007 (Haryana);

A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, district Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and
at Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra).
Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.

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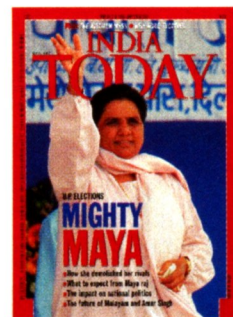
Move over Sonia Gandhi. Indian politics has a new diva and her name is Mayawati, the most intriguing political phenomenon of our times. In just a few weeks of adroit political manoeuvring, she has emerged as the second most powerful woman politician in the country and a candidate for the next prime minister of India. "Nothing can stop me becoming prime minister," she told INDIA TODAY in an exclusive interview to Editor Prabhu Chawla. After stealing the thunder from the Congress and the BJP by parading her rainbow coalition of political leaders who have pledged her support, including the recently divorced Left Front, on the day the trust vote was taking place in Parliament, that no longer sounds like an empty boast.

The 10-party alliance she now heads has the potential to make inroads into the votebanks of both the Congress and the BJP, while she herself has transformed from a one-dimensional Dalit icon into a leader who can change the dynamics of national politics. Last May, when she scripted a remarkable victory in the Uttar Pradesh elections; she did so by winning over large chunks of Brahmin and Muslim voters, apart from her rock solid Dalit base. Since then, she has expanded her reach, winning assembly seats in the North as well as the South. From the schoolteacher with aspirations of joining the IAS, to four-time chief minister and now a national leader with a hunger for the top post, it has been a remarkable journey.

We are now witnessing a new Mayawati, who once shunned cross-party dialogue, now breaking bread with leaders from across the political divide, a woman in the midst of a makeover, hair carefully styled, clothes well tailored, and extremely conscious of her image—she spent 90 minutes with Photo Editor Bandep Singh posing for the cover shot. In contrast to her previous chip-on-the-shoulder demeanour, she is now far more affable, confident and extrovert. From avoiding the media, she now cultivates it, projecting herself as a mature leader with a wider agenda than she has revealed till now.

However, it is still a work in progress. She avoids questions on the economy, on foreign policy and admits that she has not read the nuclear agreement with the US. Yet, no one can deny that she has grabbed the Opposition space from the BJP and threatens to do the same to its votebanks, as well as that of the Congress. With both parties on a decline, she is poised to grow in stature on the national stage. She may not have a clear-cut agenda but neither did Deve Gowda nor I.K. Gujral when they became prime minister.

Our cover story looks at the evolution of Mayawati, her politics, her strengths and weaknesses, her political alliances, whether her social re-engineering can work on the national level, and, above all, what she needs to do to fulfil her dream of becoming prime minister in 2009. Watch her and this space.



Our May 2007 cover

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)